

LittleReads

Kemi and the Secret Garden

Nature

Ages 6–8

by LittleReads Editorial Team

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At the best thing about the new house was the feeling of change. The walls
were a new color, the floor was different, and she missed her old friends.

Chapter 1: Behind the Wall

One morning, while exploring the garden, Kemi noticed a crack in the old wall. Through the crack, she could see green leaves and something that sparkled.

She pushed gently on the wall. A section of it swung open like a door.

Kemi stepped through and gasped.

The most beautiful garden she had ever seen spread out before her. There were flowers of every colour — red, yellow, purple, white — and a small pond where tadpoles swam in circles.

"Who did this?" she wondered.

The garden was wild and overgrown, but clearly someone had once loved it very much. There were paths, now covered in moss, and a small stone bench beneath a mango tree.

Chapter 2: Learning to Tend

Kemi showed the garden to her mother, who smiled knowingly.

"Ah," she said. "Mrs. Olumide, the previous owner, loved gardening. She was very old, and she could no longer tend the garden. That is why it has gone wild."

Kemi's mother gave her some gardening gloves and a small trowel. "If you want to bring it back to life, this is a good place to start."

Day after day, Kemi worked in the garden. She pulled weeds carefully, watered the thirsty plants, and cleared the paths.

At first, she did not know which plants were flowers and which were weeds. She made mistakes. She pulled up a beautiful lavender thinking it was a weed, and felt terrible.

"You will learn," her mother said. "Every gardener makes mistakes. The garden forgives, and so should you."

Chapter 3: The Pond of Life

The pond was Kemi's favourite discovery. In the water, she could see tiny tadpoles swimming around.

"What are they?" she asked her mother.

"Those are baby frogs. They will grow legs, lose their tails, and one day hop out of the pond as little frogs."

Kemi watched them every day, amazed at how they changed. One tadpole grew front legs first. Another grew back legs first. They all changed in their own time.

"Every creature in this garden has a purpose," her mother told her. "The bees pollinate the flowers. The earthworms keep the soil healthy. The frogs eat the insects. It is a whole ecosystem working together."

"Like a team?" asked Kemi.

"Exactly like a team. And when one part is missing, the whole team struggles."

Chapter 4: The Garden Grows

Months passed, and the garden transformed. Kemi planted new flowers and vegetables. She built a small birdhouse. She cleared the pond so the frogs had a clean home.

Other children in the neighbourhood heard about Kemi's garden and came to help. Together, they built a compost bin, planted sunflowers, and made a sign: "The Secret Garden of Kemi — Open to All."

One day, an elderly woman walked through the garden gate. Her eyes filled with tears.

"Mrs. Olumide!" Kemi exclaimed.

"You brought it back," said the old woman, touching a rose petal gently. "My garden lives again."

Mrs. Olumide sat on the stone bench and told Kemi stories about the garden — how she planted each tree, named each flower bed, and spent forty years watching it grow.

Chapter 5: The Lesson of the Garden

As the sun set, Mrs. Olumide took Kemi's hand.

"A garden teaches you the most important lessons in life, Kemi. It teaches patience — because you cannot rush a seed. It teaches responsibility — because a garden needs daily care. And it teaches that beautiful things grow when you give them time, attention, and love."

Kemi looked around at her garden — at the flowers, the frogs, the birds, and the children who came to play.

"I understand," she said. "And I will take care of it forever."

Mrs. Olumide smiled. "That is all I ever wanted."

That night, Kemi lay in bed and listened to the crickets singing from the garden. She was no longer lonely. She had a garden, new friends, and the deep knowledge that when you care for living things, they care for you right back.

What We Learned

- Ecosystems are teams of living things that depend on each other.
- Gardens require patience, care, and daily attention.
- Every creature in nature has a role to play.
- Caring for living things teaches us responsibility.

Discussion Questions

1. What living things can you find in your neighbourhood?
2. Why is every creature in a garden important?
3. What would you plant in your own secret garden?

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Thank you for reading!

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